HILCHOT SHABBAT

Criss-Cross, Not Circles: How to Mix Food on Shabbat

Given Thursday 5 November 2026 · Hilchot Shabbat | Siman 321 & 324:3

How to Mix Food on Shabbat: The Principles of מלאכת לש

Class Notes — Rabbi Daniel Kada

Sefer: Shulchan Aruch, Orach Chaim, Siman 321, with Siman 324:3 and the Biur Halacha

When: Thursdays, 6:00–7:00pm on Zoom

Next week: the remaining se'ifim of lash in Siman 321 (14–16)

Tonight's Plan

Last week we finished **טוחן** (grinding) and began **לש** (kneading).

The Rabbi calls lash one of the most complicated and most misunderstood melachot:

"There is very little guidance on it, in English or in Hebrew, certainly for the Sephardim."

The plan for tonight:

1. Review last week's principles.
2. Add the remaining principles.
3. The psak halacha.
4. Common examples.
5. Read inside, if there is time.

The whole of lash in the Shulchan Aruch is only four se'ifim: three in Siman 321, and one in Siman 324. Tonight we read the one in 324.

Part One — The Principles

1. What is lash?

Lash is **binding separate particles into one unified mass**, through a liquid.

It applies to food, such as oil with mashed aubergine, or milk with Weetabix. It also applies to non-food, such as water with earth.

2. Is putting the ingredients together already lash?

This is the big machloket of the Tannaim.

Rabbi Yosi bar Rabbi Yehuda says the melacha is only **the kneading**. Pouring water onto flour, without kneading, is not an issur d'oraita.

Rabbi (Yehuda HaNasi) says even **putting the ingredients together** is already lash, because it starts the mingling.

	Only the kneading (Rabbi Yosi)	Even putting together (Rabbi)
Rishonim	Rambam, Rif, Rosh, and most Rishonim	Yere'im, Ba'al HaTerumah, Semag, Semak
Shulchan Aruch	The main opinion (סתם)	The second opinion (יש אומרים)
Who follows it	Sefardim (Chacham Ovadia)	Ashkenazim (the Rema)

Some Sefardi poskim are strict as well, because the Shulchan Aruch did bring the second opinion.

3. Everyone forbids the kneading

Even according to Rabbi, the kneading is a **second**, separate issur d'oraita.

So if the ingredients were put together before Shabbat, you still may not knead them on Shabbat.

"Everyone agrees that the kneading together is the prohibition. The question is whether the putting together is a prohibition or not."

4. When putting together *is* the kneading

Sometimes the ingredients **bind by themselves**, the moment they touch. Then even Rabbi Yosi forbids putting them together. The Gemara's example: **הנותן זרע פשתן במים חייב.** Flaxseed in water binds on its own.

Flour and water are different. They begin to mingle, but they only become dough once you knead.

The Rabbi's example from last week: a little milk on Weetabix crumbs becomes one mass straight away. In his view, that is **forbidden d'oraita according to everyone**.

5. Three levels of mixture

Level	What it looks like	Example	Status
בלילה עבה (thick)	Hardly moves when tilted	Dough	D'oraita
בלילה רכה (thin)	Flows when you tilt the bowl	Cake batter	Derabbanan
בלילה דלה (runny)	Not a mixture at all	Cocoa in milk	Mutar

Why is a thin mixture forbidden at all? Because it is **עובדין דחול**, a very weekday activity.

6. No unified mass, no lash

Lash means the result is one unified mass. Just sticking things together is not lash.

So you may make a sandwich. Bread with chocolate spread is not "kneading the bread with the spread."

7. Things that never fully unify

Some things become one mass when kneaded. Flour and water are like that. They are called **בר גיבול**.

Others mix, but never fully unify, however much you knead. They are called **לאו בר גיבול**.

The Gemara's examples are ash, coarse sand, and bran.

"Kids at the beach, playing with the water and the sand. It mingles, but it doesn't become a proper mass the way dough does."

What does Rabbi Yosi say about these? Two Amoraim disagree (Shabbat 18):

- **Abaye:** pouring the water in is already the melacha. Kneading it achieves almost nothing anyway.
- **Rav Yosef:** you are only chayav once you knead.

Mishnah Berurah	Chazon Ish and Chacham Ovadia
Follows **Abaye**	Follows **Rav Yosef**
Pouring water on is already asur d'oraita	Nothing until you knead

And if you do knead something that never fully unifies? The **Rambam** says it is only derabbanan. **Most Rishonim** say it is d'oraita.

8. The great heter: criss-cross strokes (שתי וערב)

"This is the major heter of lash, and we're going to use it a lot."

Normally you mix **in circles**.

If instead you mix **in crossing strokes**, one way and then the other, it is permitted. Lift the spoon out each time before changing direction.

Why does it work? It is a big change from the normal way, like crushing with the back of a knife in tochen. And the result is not fully, properly mixed.

This heter works for everything, and that is the practice.

A note in brackets: the Gemara gives this heter for bran. The Rambam might limit it to cases that are only derabbanan. Other Rishonim apply it everywhere, and we follow them.

9. Why criss-cross isn't enough for Ashkenazim

For Sefardi practice it is simple. Only the kneading is forbidden. So put the ingredients in however you like, then mix criss-cross. Even a thick mixture is fine.

For Ashkenazi practice it is harder. Putting the ingredients together is already forbidden. A change in the mixing doesn't undo that.

"So you're stuck. What can Ashkenazim do? Nothing, seemingly."

The Ashkenazi solution has two parts:

1. Make only a **thin mixture**. It is only derabbanan.
2. Because it is only derabbanan, a small change is enough: **reverse the normal order** of the ingredients.

Example — baby cereal. Normally you put in the milk, then the cereal. An Ashkenazi puts in the cereal first, then the milk. He adds enough milk to keep it thin.

Does he also need criss-cross strokes? Most poskim say no. The Mishnah Berurah says it is good to do so. So it is **praiseworthy**, not required.

When may Ashkenazim make a thick mixture?

In four cases:

1. The ingredients were **put together before Shabbat**. Then just mix criss-cross.
2. For a **baby** who needs that particular food.
3. A **non-Jew** put the ingredients together. (*"Quite rare — leave that."*)

טעמו מתקלקל: made before Shabbat, it **won't taste fresh**.

Even then, put the ingredients in reverse order, and mix criss-cross.

Part Two — Inside: Siman 324:3

"It's talking about animals, but it's the same principle."

אין גובלין מורסן לבהמה, אבל נותנים בו מים ומעבירו בטרבד או מכה בו שתי וערב.

You may not knead bran for animals by hand.

But you may put the water in, and then mix it with a utensil, **criss-cross**.

You may even do this in a huge bowl for many animals: **ואפילו כור ואפילו כוריים**.

ויש אוסרים ליתן מים על גבי מורסן בשבת.

Some forbid even putting the water in. In their view, criss-cross only helps if the water was added before Shabbat. This is the Ba'al HaTerumah.

"So you see — סתם ויש." The main opinion is Rabbi Yosi. The second opinion is Rabbi.

The Biur Halacha

Normally the halacha follows Rabbi against a single colleague. Here, though, there is an anonymous Mishnah (סתם משנה) like Rabbi Yosi, and that wins.

The Biur Halacha concludes that the Shulchan Aruch's own view is **to be lenient** about putting the water in. The Rif, the Rosh and the Rambam stand together on this, as do the Ra'avad, the Ramban, the Ran, the Meiri and others.

Most Rishonim follow Rabbi Yosi.

Part Three — Practical Examples

"I wrote this document eight years ago. Some things I would change today, but fine."

The Rabbi will share it on the group after the shiur is posted.

Techina

Making techina from ground sesame and water is forbidden for everyone. It binds by itself, just like flaxseed.

Thinning ready-made techina with water is fine. You are loosening it, which is the opposite of lash.

Ready-made techina that is too thick: you may pour water on top. Then mix it in criss-cross. This works even for Ashkenazim, because something that thick doesn't start mingling until you stir.

Aubergine salad

	Thick result	Thin result
Sefardim	Mix criss-cross	Fine
Ashkenazim	Only in special cases: oil first, then aubergine, then criss-cross	Oil first, then aubergine. Criss-cross is praiseworthy

Most aubergine and oil salads are thin anyway.

With thick mayonnaise, even Ashkenazim may put it together in any order. Just mix criss-cross. Thick mayonnaise doesn't mingle until you stir.

Chilbe (fenugreek)

Some Sefardim eat chilbe on Rosh Hashanah, especially the Adenim and Teimanim. The Syrians eat rubia (black-eyed beans) instead.

The Rabbi's family keeps **both customs**, because his wife is Adeni.

"Why chilbe? Because it increases so quickly. A tiny drop makes so much."

Making chilbe on Shabbat is forbidden for everyone. It binds and expands by itself, just like flaxseed.

Salads

Lettuce salads are never cut small enough to become one mass. Add oil, mayonnaise and salt as normal.

Potato salad is usually in pieces, so mix normally. If it is mashed potato, or mashed avocado, mix criss-cross.

Egg and onion, liver, tuna

With oil or mayonnaise, these usually make a thick mixture.

Sefardim: mix criss-cross.

Ashkenazim: make it before Shabbat. If it genuinely won't taste the same, make it on Shabbat with the order reversed, and mix criss-cross.

Does "it won't taste fresh" still apply, now that we have fridges? The Rabbi remembers Rabbi Falk saying no. *"But I've seen many Ashkenazim disagree. If you genuinely feel the taste isn't the same, there's plenty to rely on."*

Avocado with lemon

Sefardim: a thick mixture is fine, mixed criss-cross.

Ashkenazim: use plenty of lemon to keep it thin. Put the lemon in first, then the avocado.

Cereal, Weetabix and porridge

Cornflakes with milk: eat normally. But lots of crushed cornflakes in a little milk will clump at once.

Weetabix or porridge: not in the normal way, **even for Sefardim**. A little milk binds it immediately.

Instead, pour in **a lot of milk**, so it stays runny, and mix criss-cross.

Thick yoghurt with banana may be mixed on Shabbat. Made the day before, it wouldn't be very tasty.

Summary

What lash is: binding separate particles into one mass, through a liquid.

Sefardim: only the kneading is forbidden. Put the ingredients in any order, and mix **criss-cross**.

Ashkenazim: putting together is also forbidden. Make a **thin** mixture, with the ingredients in **reverse order**.

Forbidden for everyone: things that bind by themselves. Techina from sesame, chilbe, and Weetabix with a little milk.

Thick mayonnaise and very thick techina don't mingle until you stir. So even Ashkenazim may put them together, then mix criss-cross.

Coming Up

Next week: the last three se'ifim of lash in **Siman 321 (14–16)**.

"They're very complex to understand, not clear at all what they mean."

Shabbat Shalom.

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